

POWER TO WITNESS

* Red denotes writing on screen

TEXT: Acts 1:8 (KJV) “*But ye shall receive power, after that the Holy Ghost is come upon you: and ye shall be witnesses unto me both in Jerusalem, and in all Judaea, and in Samaria, and unto the uttermost part of the earth.*”

INTRO: Not all of us have the gift of an evangelist but we all have a responsibility for evangelism.

This frightens some people and excites others.

The BIG question is the how to of evangelism. This is explained with two words in one verse – Acts 1:8 – “*Power – Witnesses*”.

These are the final words of Jesus before His ascension into Heaven. They must be pretty

important instructions because they are parting instructions.

These words clearly define the mission of the church. They also reveal the evangelistic pattern for the church. The mission of the church and the evangelistic pattern of the church are one and the same: “***Receive power***” - “***Be witnesses***”

The Greek word for “***Power***” is “*Dunamis*”; (**Power = Dunamis**) and the Greek word for “***Witnesses***” is “*Martus*” (**Witnesses = Martus**). We are going to look closely today at these two words and draw some implications from what we find.

DUNAMIS

This word “***Power***” is speaking of the “*Dunamis*” of the God of the universe! The “*Dunamis*” of God belongs to God. Therefore, only God can give His “*Dunamis*” away!

The word “*Dunamis*” is used 120 times in the Greek New Testament. 77 times it is translated as Power. It is also translated as:

- Virtue
- Strength
- Miracles
- Might works

The basic meaning is:

- Power
- Strength
- Ability

It is inherent power, or power that resides within. This power resides within the believer by virtue of its nature. For the believer this includes:

- Moral power
- Money power
- Military power
- Miracle working power

In his book *"The Gifts of the Spirit,"* Harold Horton defines the miraculous power of God in the following ways:

- *"A miracle is a supernatural act on the natural plane."*
- *"Works contrary to nature, accomplishments, so to speak, of the impossible, sudden and unaccountable reversals of the order to which we are accustomed."*
- *"A miracle is a supernatural intervention in the ordinary course of nature; a temporary suspension of the accustomed order; an interruption of the system of nature as we know it."*
- *"A miracle is a sovereign act of the Spirit of God irrespective of laws or systems."*

This power is not limited by what we feel or don't feel; by what we see or don't see; by what we do or don't do. It is the all-encompassing "*Dunamis*" of God. It manifests itself in many ways but some of them include:

- Signs
- Miracles
- Wonders
- Witnessing
- Moral excellence

And, this is the power which the Father desires to bestow upon each and every one of us! Will we receive it? Or, better yet, will we properly steward it? If you don't have it, you should get it. If you have it you should let it use you!

MARTUS

The word "*Martus*" is used 34 times in the Greek New Testament. 29 times it is translated witness. It is also translated as martyr!

"Martus" = Witness - Martyr

A witness gives testimony through:

- Words
- Actions
- Testimony

There are several ways of understanding this word:

- A witness in a courtroom
- Someone who watches an event - A spectator - An eye witness
- One who gives his life for a cause

This word certainly embraces the idea of a verbal witness or even preaching. But it is much more. The New Testament gives many examples of this but the two I want to point to is Steven and Paul.

Steven was a witness in multiple ways:

- He was full of faith and the Holy Spirit. (Acts 6:5) It was visible in his life.
- He did great wonders among the people. (Acts 6:8)
- He spoke with power. (Acts 6:10)
- He showed moral courage in death. (Acts 7:56-60)

Paul:

- He consented to the death of Steven, (Acts 8:1) and Stevens witness in death no doubt contributed to Paul's conversion.
- Throughout his life Paul witnessed through powerful preaching, signs, wonders, and moral character.
- Paul gave his life as a "*Martus*" martyr. ***"To live is Christ, to die is gain."*** In other words, *"If I live the devil loses and everyone else wins. If I die the devil loses and I win."*

CONCLUSION:

The First Century Church was emboldened by the Dunamis of God and committed to the Martus of God.

As a result the Gospel spread, ***"From Jerusalem, throughout all of Judea, to Samaria, and the uttermost parts of the earth."***

These people who were filled with the Dunamis of God, and committed to the Martus of Christ,

were the very ones who “*Turned their world upside down.*”

If we have the Dunamis of God as we say we do, and are committed to the Martus of Christ, what do we have to show for it, and what do we plan to do with it?

If you have never received the Dunamis of God you are about to be given an opportunity to receive it.

I must warn you – This gift should come with a warning label – **WARNING: The Dunamis of God will compel you to give yourself to the Martus of Christ.**